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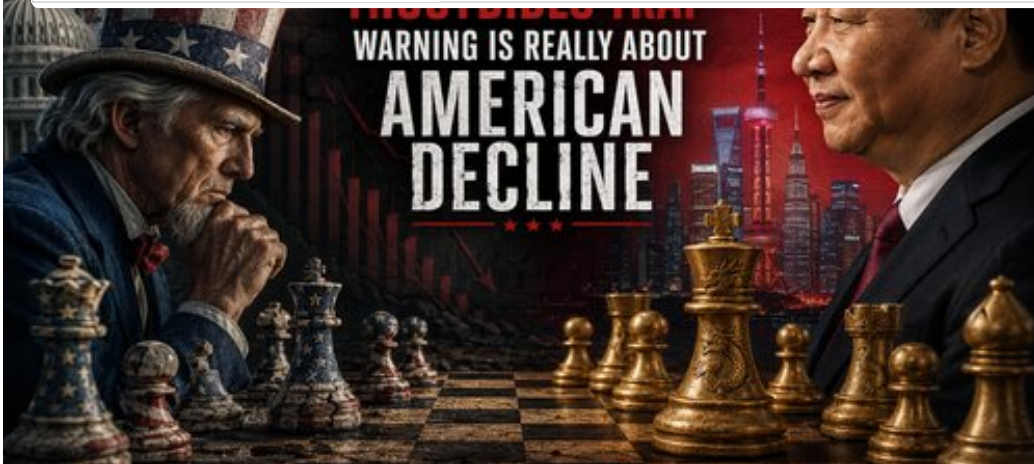


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ARTICLE

Xi Jinping's 'Thucydides Trap' Warning Is Really About American Decline



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BY PNW STAFF MAY 15, 2026

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Google searches for the phrase "Thucydides Trap" surged after Chinese President Xi Jinping used the term during discussions surrounding his high-stakes meeting with President Donald Trump. For many Americans, it was likely the first time they had ever heard the phrase.

But in Beijing, it was not an obscure historical reference casually thrown into conversation.

In China's leadership circles, the phrase carries enormous strategic weight. It refers to the ancient idea, first written about by Greek historian Thucydides, that war often becomes likely when a rising power begins challenging an established one. In this case, the rising power is clearly China, and the established superpower is the United States.

But the most important part of Xi's warning may not be that China is rising. Rising powers have always existed throughout history. The deeper issue is this: China increasingly appears to believe America is vulnerable enough to challenge.

That should concern every American regardless of political party.

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China No Longer Sees Itself As A Secondary Power

For decades, China carefully avoided directly confronting the United States on the world stage. Its leaders emphasized "peaceful rise," economic cooperation, and global trade integration. China became

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Xi Jinping no longer speaks like the leader of a developing nation trying to find its place in the world. He speaks like the head of a civilization convinced its moment has arrived.

And perhaps more importantly, convinced America's best days may be fading.

Great Powers Are Usually Challenged When They Look Weak

Historically, rising powers rarely challenge nations that appear unified, economically dominant, culturally confident, and militarily overwhelming. They move when weakness becomes visible.

That is where this story stops being only about China and starts becoming about America itself.

The uncomfortable truth is that America increasingly projects instability to the outside world. China watches America's soaring debt, political paralysis, violent social division, border chaos, inflation struggles, and cultural fragmentation. It sees a nation deeply distracted by internal conflict.

America's national debt continues climbing toward levels once considered unimaginable. Trust in institutions has collapsed across much of the population. Military recruitment has struggled in recent years. Entire sectors of American manufacturing have become dependent on Chinese supply chains. Political tribalism has grown so intense that many Americans now view each other as enemies rather than fellow citizens.

From Beijing's perspective, this matters.

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History Shows Decline Often Begins Internally

History shows that great powers often begin declining internally before they are challenged externally. The Roman Empire did not fall in a single battle. Britain's global dominance faded gradually after economic strain and geopolitical exhaustion weakened its position.

Even during the Cold War, America projected industrial strength, national confidence, and a broad sense of shared purpose that deterred direct conflict with the Soviet Union.

Today, China may be calculating something different.

Xi Jinping's reference to the "Thucydides Trap" was likely not just a warning about conflict. It may also have been a subtle declaration that China believes the global balance of power is shifting for the first time in generations.

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For China, Taiwan is not merely a nearby island. It is a symbol of unfinished national ambition and a critical strategic target. For the United States, Taiwan represents far more than geography. It is central to global semiconductor production and sits along a vital defense line in the Pacific.

The danger is not simply intentional war. History shows major conflicts often emerge through miscalculation. Imperial Germany believed Britain lacked the resolve to stop its rise. Japan underestimated American response before the Attack on Pearl Harbor. Misreading weakness has repeatedly pushed nations into catastrophic decisions.

That is why perceptions matter so much.

If China increasingly views America as internally divided, economically strained, and uncertain of its own identity, Beijing may become more willing to test boundaries that previous Chinese leaders avoided.

America Still Has Time -- But Denial Is Dangerous

None of this means American decline is inevitable.

The United States remains the world's most powerful military force and still possesses enormous economic, technological, and cultural influence. America has repeatedly recovered from periods of crisis throughout its history. But recovery begins with recognizing reality rather than pretending dangerous trends do not exist.

Xi Jinping's warning should not merely be viewed as a foreign policy talking point or a fascinating historical reference. It should be understood as something far more sobering.

America's greatest adversaries are watching closely. They are studying the nation's debt, division, cultural instability, and political dysfunction. And some may increasingly believe the era of unquestioned American dominance is coming to an end.

The real danger behind the "Thucydides Trap" is not simply that China is rising.

It is that Beijing may believe America no longer has the unity, confidence, or strength to stop it.



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